

CRM COMPARISON TIER 2 — AIRTABLE VS HUBSPOT VS PIPEDRIVE

For 2 users, land focus, API-first agent operation · June 25, 2026 · Full doc: [crm-comparison.html](#)

RECOMMENDATION: **Airtable Free** remains the top choice. **Pipedrive Lite (\$14/seat/mo)** is the strongest "real CRM" alternative if a pre-built deal pipeline becomes preferable to building it in Airtable. **HubSpot Free** is viable but has a steep custom-objects cliff at \$890/mo + \$3K onboarding.

FEATURE MATRIX

FEATURE	AIRTABLE ☆	HUBSPOT	PIPEDRIVE
Annual cost (2 users, starting tier)	\$0 (Free, 5 editors, 1K records/base)	\$0 (Free, 2 users, 1 deal pipeline) or \$360/yr (Starter \$15/seat)	\$336/yr (Lite \$14/seat) — no free tier
Land-friendly (APN, no address req)	Fully customizable	Custom properties OK	Custom fields included
Deal pipeline (kanban, stages)	Build yourself (template avail)	1 pipeline on free	Pipeline-native — core product
Custom fields per record	Unlimited, any type	Starter+ only	Plan-limited but generous
Custom objects (Properties as 1st-class)	Native (just create base)	Enterprise tier — \$890/mo	Workaround via deal labels
API — read records	Full REST + Python SDK	World-class — Node/Python SDK	Full REST + dev community
API — update lead status	Yes — any field	Yes — full PATCH	Yes — deal stage API
API — query/filter records	Formulas + filterByFormula	CRM search API + lists	Search API + filters
API — bulk operations	Up to 10 records/call	Up to 100 records/call (batch)	Standard pagination
Native webhooks (built-in)	Yes	Yes	Yes — recently expanded
API rate limits (free/starter)	5 req/sec per base — generous	100 req / 10 sec, 250K/day	~20K-100K calls/day plan-dep.
Mail integration (postcards)	PostcardMania/Click2Mail via Zap	Via Zapier	Via Zapier
Built-in phone/dialer	No — Twilio integration	Calling add-on \$50/mo	Caller add-on built-in
Skip tracing	PropStream handles it	PropStream handles it	PropStream handles it
Multi-user (2 partners)	5 editors on free	2 users on free	2+ on paid (no free)
Auditability / revision history	Per-cell revision history	Activity timeline + audit logs	Per-field history
Setup complexity	Medium — template + config	Low — guided onboarding	Low — pipeline ready
Land-specific features built-in	None (build yourself)	None (general-purpose)	None (general-purpose)
Cost cliff / hidden trap	Linear: \$0 → \$20/seat at scale	⚠ Custom Objects: \$890/mo + \$3K onboarding	Linear: Lite → Growth → Premium
Reputation / industry standing	Industry standard, 300K+ co	Largest SMB CRM, public co	100K+ companies, EU-built

WHY AIRTABLE STILL WINS

- **\$0 to start** — only platform with free tier that includes API access at usable limits
- **Custom objects native** — Properties, Owners, Mailers, Deals all as first-class objects without an Enterprise upcharge
- **5 req/sec rate limit** — generous; HubSpot free/starter is 100 req/10s which gets tight for agent operations
- **No cost cliff** — linear scaling, \$0 → \$20/seat/mo if you outgrow the free tier
- **Per-cell revision history** — full audit trail of every change

HUBSPOT — STRONGEST API, WORST COST TRAP

- **API quality is unmatched** — full SDKs in Node/Python/Ruby, batch endpoints (100 records/call), Zapier-free
- **Free tier real:** 2 users, unlimited contacts (1K marketing), 1 pipeline
- **BUT free tier blocks custom properties** — Starter \$15/seat to unlock
- **Custom Objects are Enterprise-only** — \$890/mo base + \$3,000 mandatory onboarding fee
- **Marketing contact pricing** kicks in once you mail more than 1,000 prospects

- **Paul Brewer's land template** already exists for property tracking

PIPEDRIVE — STRONGEST ALTERNATIVE

- **Built FOR deal pipelines** — kanban, drag-and-drop stages, deal aging, all native
- **\$14/seat/mo Lite** = \$336/yr for 2 users — cheapest dedicated CRM with a real API
- **Custom fields included** at every tier (HubSpot locks them behind Starter)
- **Strong API + active dev community** — May 2026 changelog shows ongoing improvements
- **Built-in calling** via Caller add-on — useful when Chris's call system goes live
- **Verdict:** Best if you want a pre-built pipeline instead of building in Airtable. Reassess at Phase 2.

- **Verdict:** Great if you stay on free forever or are fine on Starter. Risky if growth demands Properties as a custom object.

⚠️ **HubSpot trap:** Going from \$0 (Free) to \$890/mo when you need Custom Objects (e.g., Properties as objects) is a 60x leap. There is no middle tier. Many bootstrapped users get caught here.

COST COMPARISON — 2 USERS, ANNUAL

TIER	AIRTABLE	HUBSPOT	PIPEDRIVE
Starting (free/cheapest)	\$0/yr	\$0/yr (Free) → \$360/yr (Starter)	\$336/yr (Lite)
Mid-tier (real CRM features)	\$480/yr (Team \$20/seat)	\$10,680/yr (Pro) + \$3K onboarding	\$936/yr (Growth) — automation included
Enterprise-grade	\$1,200/yr (Business \$50/seat)	\$43,200/yr + \$7K onboarding	\$1,896/yr (Ultimate)

Sources: [airtable.com](#) · [hubspot.com legal/product catalog](#) · [saaszap.com](#) (HubSpot pricing 2026) · [devdecide.com](#) (HubSpot API limits) · [pipedrive.com/pricing](#) · [devcommunity.pipedrive.com](#) (May 2026 API changelog) · Prepared by Gerald 🍊